

ENLP East Africa Global Intensive Reflection Report

Rwanda & Uganda · Global Livingston Institute

I. Leadership

Goals

1. Understand the dynamic of the group I was traveling with and how effective leadership operates across cultural contexts
2. Recognize my own role within the group and identify leadership styles I want to carry forward

Activities

1. Daily group debriefs facilitated by GLI (Global Livingston Institute, the organization the trip was partnered with) staff member Kinani, focused on building mutual respect and drawing out meaningful reflection
2. Observation of Kinani's real-time crisis communication during schedule disruptions caused by bus delays in Rwanda's hills
3. Engineering challenge with Kabale University students, which required me to adapt my approach in a cross-cultural team environment

Evaluation

1. Rather than holding a formal leadership position on this trip, the most significant growth I experienced was in how I observed and internalized effective leadership in action. GLI staff member Kinani consistently modeled a leadership style built on deep mutual respect. By establishing this foundation early, he was able to facilitate group discussions that were honest and reflective. This culture of respect was not unique to Kinani; it was a thread woven through interactions across both Rwanda and Uganda.
2. What stood out most in Kinani's leadership was how he handled adversity. When our bus struggled through the hills of Rwanda and we fell behind schedule, Kinani did not dwell on the original plan or create anxiety about what had been missed. He addressed the problem on his end, typically by contacting the groups we were meeting to inform them of the delay, then communicated the updated plan clearly and moved with urgency himself. By communicating only what was still actionable and modeling urgency without stress, he gave the group everything it needed to adapt without wasting energy on what had already changed. This is a leadership principle I intend to carry forward.
3. The engineering challenge with Kabale University students also put me in an unexpected leadership position. My group included several highly intelligent but quiet individuals, which made early brainstorming difficult. To get the group moving, I modeled the behavior I wanted to see: I offered my best idea first, then deliberately threw out an idea I knew was flawed. When one team member professionally pointed out why it would not work, I agreed and used the moment to reframe the exercise. I suggested we spend several minutes saying anything at all, write everything down, and sort through it afterward. This shifted the group's energy. I led by being vulnerable and by making it safe to

contribute imperfect ideas. That is a form of leadership I had not previously had to practice across a cultural gap, and it gave me a more concrete sense of what psychological safety means in practice.

II. Cross-Cultural Communication

Goals

1. Converse effectively and meaningfully with community members, partner organizations, and peer students across Rwanda and Uganda
2. Understand how communication norms differ across cultural contexts and what those differences reveal

Activities

1. Student exchange and engineering challenge with Kabale University Faculty of Engineering students
2. Daily interactions with GLI staff, local hosts, and community members across Lake Bunyonyi and Kigali
3. Group debriefs with Kinani establishing shared norms for honest, respectful dialogue

Evaluation

1. One of the most formative cross-cultural communication experiences of the trip came during the engineering challenge presentations with Kabale University students. After our group presented, a student named Victor stood up to ask questions. He opened by genuinely and warmly thanking the presenters, and then proceeded to interrogate the project with extraordinary precision and vigor. He identified every potential flaw, pressed for justification of every design choice, and if an answer fell short, he pushed further. When time ran out, the facilitators had to cut him off. As he sat down, he shook the presenters' hands and told them they had done a good job.
2. At school in Boulder, this style of questioning is often perceived as aggressive or self-promotional. Victor's approach reframed it entirely. His questioning was not competitive; it was an act of investment. He wanted the project to be as strong as possible, and he trusted his peers enough to be completely honest with them. The respect was not performative; it was embedded in the intensity of his engagement. Watching this made me think differently about how I give and receive feedback. I tend to soften criticism to preserve comfort, and while that has value, there is something powerful about a culture that treats rigorous critique as a form of respect.

III. Cross-Cultural Understanding

Goals

1. Develop a deeper understanding of Rwandan and Ugandan history, community values, and daily life
2. Understand how the region's past shapes its present, and what that means for engineering, leadership, and development

Activities

1. Visits to the Kigali Genocide Memorial and Nyamata Genocide Memorial, including conversation with current Rwandan high school students
2. Community immersion at Lake Bunyonyi, including a tour of GLI's community development programs and model farm
3. Tour of the Africa Rising Cycling Center in Musanze, founded with presidential investment
4. Site visits to Engineers Without Borders Rwanda, Recycl'Africa, Zipline, and Partners for Conservation

Evaluation

1. What struck me most at the Kigali and Nyamata Genocide Memorials was not the scale of the violence, but its intimacy. The 1994 genocide was neighbors turning on neighbors. People who had shared meals, raised children on the same streets, and built lives in the same communities became perpetrators and victims within days. Understanding this made Rwanda's recovery feel even more extraordinary. The country did not rebuild despite its history; it rebuilt through a collective decision to choose unity over division and shared purpose over individual grievance.
2. This theme of collective investment showed up everywhere I looked. Conversations with high school students revealed that many of them were working side jobs just to pay for secondary school, driven by the hope that education might open a path to university. A community member described a practice that has stayed with me: when a fruit tree is planted, anyone in the community can take from it, regardless of who planted it. This is not an exception or an act of charity; it is simply how things work. The community owns its resources collectively, and contributing to shared infrastructure is understood as part of what it means to be a member of that community.
3. The Africa Rising Cycling Center in Musanze crystallized this for me in a concrete way. The facility's weight room used concrete blocks as weights. The bikes, however, were state of the art, and the athletes who trained there had won the Tour du Rwanda in 2014. Presidential investment in a single focused resource had created a community of young athletes competing at the highest levels — not despite limited overall resources, but because of deliberate, well-placed investment. Rwanda is a compelling case study in what a country can accomplish in a short period of time when its people and its leadership unify around a shared purpose.

Photos from the Trip



Doing math with local high school students



Playing a drumbeat and dancing with local children



Karaoke with Kabale University students



The view from our accommodations at Lake Bunyonyi



Exercising at the Africa Rising Cycling Center